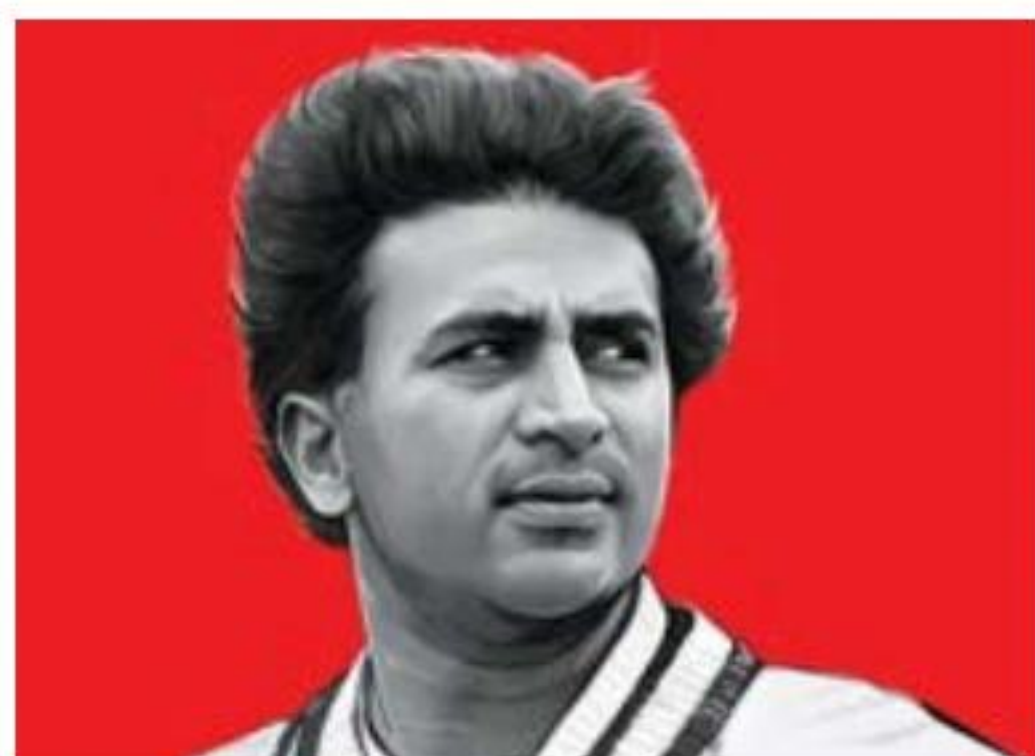




ON THE WRITE LINE

Sunil Gavaskar



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PRIYANK PANCHAL DIDN'T GET THE INDIA CAP, BUT THAT DOESN'T MAKE HIS CONTRIBUTION TO INDIAN CRICKET ANY LESS

From time immemorial, this has been the case in not just Indian cricket but world cricket, where **some very good players** have missed out on their country's cap.

This year's Indian Premier League (IPL) saw a new champion. Two long-suffering teams — Royal Challengers Bengaluru and Punjab Kings — battled for the title in the best T20 league in the world. In the end, RCB came out on top, ending an 18-year wait.

That said, this column carries great pleasure and quite a bit of sadness about the retirement of one of Indian cricket's wonderful servants. It is a great pleasure to recognise his contribution to our beloved game, and sadness because we won't see him play again in his favourite whites.

Priyank Panchal, the former Gujarat captain, made the tough call to quit Ranji Trophy cricket after serving his State for almost two decades.

He was part of the Ranji Trophy-winning Gujarat team, but if there's one regret he has, it would be that he didn't get the India cap. He came close to it on a couple of occasions but didn't have the good fortune to get it. That doesn't make his contribution to Indian cricket any less than those who have played for India. Sometimes it's just the misfortune of having been born at the same time as some others who were selected ahead of him and did well enough never to allow him to replace them.

From time immemorial, this has been the case in not just Indian cricket but world cricket, where some very good players have missed out

on their country's cap. Look at Rajinder Goel and Padmakar Shivalkar. They would have been certainties in most other countries' Test teams, but with the four great spinners in Bishan Singh Bedi, Erapalli Prasanna, BS Chandrasekhar, and S. Venkataraghavan around, they couldn't get a look-in even once. Similarly, when the Fab Five batters of Indian cricket were around, many heavy run-scorers in Ranji Trophy cricket couldn't find a place in the team. Who could replace Sachin Tendulkar, Virender Sehwag, Rahul Dravid, Sourav Ganguly, and V.V.S Laxman when they were in their pomp? So, Panchal also missed out despite scoring consistently in the domestic circuit.

Apart from not getting the India cap, he also wouldn't have much to show in his bank balance, despite spending the better part of his youth trying to make a career and a living out of the game. It is here that the lopsided nature of remuneration for other domestic tournaments and that of the IPL, another domestic tournament, stands out.

It's doubtful if, after playing for two decades in all kinds of weather conditions all over the country, including the bitter cold in the North of India and extreme heat elsewhere, and also amid rains sometimes, Panchal has made even Rs. 3 crore in Ranji Trophy fees. Compare this with uncapped players in the IPL who make Rs.